One condition. Six patterns.

Ask two questions: When is the condition? When is the result?

ZERO

General facts and repeated results

if + Present Simple
Present Simple

If I skip breakfast, I feel hungry.

A usual result. No single future occasion.

FIRST

A real future possibility

if + Present Simple
will + base verb

If I finish early, I will call you.

Tomorrow is possible. The speaker treats it as real.

SECOND

An imagined present or future

if + Past Simple
would + base verb

If I had more time, I would travel.

The past form creates distance from reality; it does not put the situation in the past.

THIRD

A different past and past result

if + had + past participle
would have + past participle

If I had left earlier, I would have caught the train.

Reality: I left too late and missed it.

MIXED A

Past condition -> present result

if + had + past participle
would + base verb

If I had accepted the job, I would live in Rome now.

Change a past choice. Imagine its effect now.

MIXED B

General state -> past result

if + Past Simple
would have + past participle

If I were more organised, I would not have missed yesterday's meeting.

The general characteristic was also relevant at the time of the past event.

Make the right choice.

A compact guide to time, questions, negatives and common mistakes.

1 / Draw the two timelines

Imagined present -> present/future: second conditional.
Past -> past: third conditional.
Past -> now: mixed A. **General state -> past:** mixed B.
A new change today cannot cause a different result yesterday.

2 / Build the negative or the question

First: If I do not finish, I will not join you.
Third: If I had not rushed, I would not have made that mistake.
Question: What would you have done if you had noticed?
Put the modal before the subject in the result question.

3 / Would, could or might?

Would = the imagined result. **Could** = ability or possibility. **Might** = a possible result.
If I had applied, I **might have got** the job. It was not guaranteed.
For a real future condition, a result can also be a modal or instruction: If you finish, you **can leave**. If you need help, **ask me**.

4 / Watch these small details

If I were you is the standard advice pattern. Were is also the formal choice for other imagined situations with be; was occurs in informal speech.
If I'd known = if I **had** known. **I'd have helped** = I **would** have helped.
Had had is correct: If I had had more time... The first had is the helper; the second is the past participle of have.

5 / Repair the usual errors

In these basic patterns: **if I finish**, not if I will finish; **if I had known**, not if I would have known.
If at the start: add a comma before the result. Result first: normally no comma.
Check the verb after would: **would go** for now; **would have gone** for a different past.
These are the core patterns. Special uses of will/would in if-clauses are a separate topic.